

| By Prabhu Chawla |

Once upon a time, there was an India that was home to leaders who could change the course of history with a slogan—or a grand gesture. It was the East's most fertile land for men and women who were mythified in the mass mind. If the maximum leader with complete copyright over people's conscience was a Communist specialty, India was one of democracy's great achievements in parading Leaders with a capital L. They were all global brands and they were all larger than their parties. Just think of some of them. As a moderniser and nation builder, Jawaharlal Nehru, the first prime minister, turned India's Grand Old Party into an instrument of national renewal. His daughter Indira, arguably the all-time chart-buster in popularity not only struck an unmatched balance between power, paranoia and charisma but played Mother India to terrifying effect. And the Right turn in Indian politics threw up a leader, Atal Behari Vajpayee, who soared above his party and, in the era of political cohabitation, united the opposites with such detached ease. Those were interesting times, and the arena inhabited by leaders who breached the limits of realpolitik and played it big and bold, always driven by a sense of the nation. That was then.

Photographs by SIPRA DAS, BANDEEP SINGH. Illustration by SAURABH SINGH



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PER CENT WAS THE VOTE SHARE OF BOTH THE CONGRESS AND ITS MAIN RIVAL, THE BJP, IN THE 2004 ELECTIONS.